

Conclusion: How to Create an Environment that Supports Female Leaders

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OK, hopefully you've made it to the end with us and you've started to get a much clearer picture on how to create an environment that supports strong female leaders.

To wrap it all up, here are a few basic principles to keep in mind.

We talked about eliminating gender bias in the hiring process. The first step to supporting women is making sure they have an equal opportunity to work at your organization and that the metrics used to screen employees are balanced. When in doubt, include a mix of genders on your hiring committees – a good practice for any hires, not just female team members!

Next, be mindful of microaggressions and gender stereotypes at your organization and begin to think of ways these can be eliminated at your organization. It may be as simple as better employee education. It may mean changing some traditions or committees, such as asking the women to bring food to the monthly potluck or being in charge of showers and other extracurriculars for employees.

Make sure performance reviews don't reward gender-biased attributes, such as "outspoken," "assertive," or "takes charge," without including qualities such as "interpersonal skills," "collaboration," "dependability," or "attention-to-detail."

To the best of your ability, offer flexibility with schedule and workspace. You also want to make sure you are offering benefits that are flexible and conducive to families. This goes without saying.

Avoid team-building activities or "awards" that favor one gender, such as boxed tickets to a sporting event or mountain retreat to a fly-fishing resort. This one is huge! These activities and perks weren't created with women in mind, any more than a night at the symphony or spa package as a team building-event would be attractive to most males. There are plenty of other gender-neutral activities and rewards to choose from, like escape rooms, game nights, vacation credits, or online gift cards.

Finally, have a zero-tolerance policy on sexual harassment. Most organizations have embraced this fully, but make sure employees know it won't be tolerated on *any* level. This includes locker-room talk, slurs, or jokes even without the opposite sex present. Such

actions contribute to the overall culture and can be insidious whether the actual female is present or not. Handle any matters quickly and confidentially.

These policies are good for *everyone*, not just for women. And when everyone benefits, the team wins!

So, as you complete this course, take a minute and think about where your organization falls. What steps can you take to get better? Which steps can you alone influence, and which might you need to suggest to others at your organization?

Supporting women in leadership is a team effort. And Pat knew how to create winning teams.

So, without further ado, let's take a closer look.